

STILL HERE, STILL HERS

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MK PARRISH

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Essays on losing yourself, surviving the in-between, and
learning to belong to your own life

Author: ♡ – MK

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This book is a work of personal nonfiction. Some names, identifying details, timelines, and scenes may be adjusted or compressed to protect privacy while preserving emotional truth.

READER NOTE

This book includes personal essays about grief, heartbreak, mental health, loneliness, body image, family loss, and rebuilding after emotional collapse. It is not medical, legal, or therapeutic advice. If any part of this book brings up something tender in you, please take care of yourself and reach toward qualified support where you need it.

DEDICATION

For the women who are still here.

For the girls in us who kept writing things down because
some part of them knew we would need a way back.

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CHAPTER 1: STILL HERE, STILL HERS

I used to think survival would feel more triumphant.

I thought if I made it through the thing that almost took me out, I would know it. There would be a clean before and after. A song would swell somewhere. I would become the kind of woman who drinks green juice, owns matching pajamas, answers texts in a healthy time frame, and speaks about her past with a calm little smile that suggests she has integrated the lesson.

Instead, survival looked like me sitting in a room I did not want to be in, wearing a body I did not know how to love, checking my phone for a message from someone who had already shown me exactly how little he was willing to give.

The room was never dramatic enough for the size of the feeling. That still bothers me. Pain should get better production design. There should be thunder. Broken glass. A skyline. Something cinematic enough to justify the way your chest caves in.

But most of mine happened under bad ceiling light.

On a bed with a charger cord twisted near my ankle.

Beside a pile of clothes I kept stepping over like it was evidence.

With a half-empty drink sweating on the nightstand and my phone faceup, bright as an accusation.

It looked like crying in public and pretending I had allergies.

It looked like one shoe from multiple pairs.

Not metaphorically. Actually.

That is the detail I keep coming back to, because it is almost too ridiculous to be tragic. At one point, my life had become so disorganized, so stripped down, so scattered by loss and instability, that I had shoes without partners. Little artifacts of a woman trying to remain presentable while everything around her had gone missing.

It is tempting to make that funny.

I know how to do that. I can turn pain into a punchline before anyone else gets the chance. I can make my own humiliation charming. I can stand in the wreckage of my life and say, "Well, at least the material is good."

And sometimes it is.

But sometimes the joke is just a door I close before anyone sees how bad it got.

The truth is, there were years when I did not feel like a person. I felt like a collection of reactions. A woman made of panic, longing, apologies, screenshots, half-plans, desperate prayers, and outfits ordered for versions of myself I kept hoping would arrive.

I bought clothes like I was summoning her.

The confident one. The healed one. The one who could walk into a room and not immediately scan it for rejection. The one who owned matching things. The one who took mirror pictures without mentally prosecuting every angle. The one who did not need a man's attention to make the day feel real.

Packages came. Versions of me did not.

I wanted to be chosen so badly that I kept mistaking attention for care.

I wanted to be safe so badly that I called anything familiar home.

I wanted to be loved so badly that I accepted the kind of closeness that left me emptier than being alone.

And beneath all of that was the quiet, embarrassing fear that maybe this was all I would ever be: too much, too late, too damaged, too dramatic, too hard to love without conditions.

That fear is not poetic when you are inside it.

It is physical.

It lives in your chest. It changes the way you breathe. It turns a silent phone into evidence. It makes you rehearse conversations with people who are not even thinking about you. It makes you refresh your own pain like a feed.

I do not know the exact moment I began to disappear from my own life.

I only know it did not happen all at once.

It happened every time I chose being understood by someone else over being honest with myself. Every time I

explained away what hurt me because naming it would have cost too much. Every time I made myself small enough to fit inside someone else's willingness.

There is a version of me who still wants to apologize for that.

She wants to say she should have known better. She should have been stronger. She should have left sooner, healed faster, loved smarter, wanted less.

But I am tired of making a crime scene out of my softness.

I was not stupid.

I was starving.

And starving people do not always make elegant choices. They reach. They cling. They convince themselves crumbs are communion because at least crumbs are something.

This book is not my attempt to look healed.

It is my attempt to stop abandoning the woman who was not.

The woman on the floor. The woman on the ferry. The woman refreshing her phone. The woman begging life to give her one clean sign that she was still worth saving.

I am not proud of every version of myself.

But I am protective of her now.

Because she stayed alive.

Because she kept writing.

Because even when she could not love herself, she left enough of a paper trail for me to find my way back.

I am still here.

That is not the whole story.

But it is the first miracle.

CHAPTER 2: MOMENTUM IS NOT HEALING

There are days when you wake up and realize you have been surviving on momentum alone.

Not hope.

Not joy.

Just the habit of putting one foot in front of the other because stopping feels more dangerous than continuing.

For a long time, I confused movement with recovery. If I was applying for jobs, rewriting my bio, making plans, starting over again, then surely I was getting better. Surely the fact that I could still produce language meant I had not completely lost myself.

But momentum is not the same thing as healing.

Momentum can keep you alive while you are still bleeding.

It can carry you through the grocery store, through the interview, through the family conversation, through another night where you are alone with the version of your life you cannot believe is yours.

It can carry you through the pharmacy aisle while you pretend to compare shampoo and actually try not to cry. It can get you to the gas station. It can get you through a job application where the form wants a clean timeline and your life has become a drawer full of tangled necklaces.

It can make you answer "I'm good" in a voice so convincing that even you almost believe it for three seconds.

It can get you dressed.

It cannot make you feel at home in your own skin.

I used to believe love was something you earned by sacrificing yourself. Somewhere early in me, that idea became law. If I gave enough, endured enough, disappeared enough, someone would stay. Someone would choose me. Someone would look at the whole messy inventory of me and decide I was still worth the trouble.

That belief did not feel unhealthy while I was living it.

It felt noble.

It felt like loyalty.

It felt like proof that I knew how to love.

This is what makes certain patterns so hard to interrupt. They do not arrive wearing a villain costume. They arrive disguised as your best qualities. Devotion. Empathy. Patience. Forgiveness. The capacity to see the wounded child inside someone who is actively harming the grown woman in you.

I have loved people like emergencies.

Like if I loved them hard enough, urgently enough, theatrically enough, I could turn the story before it ended. I could make abandonment change its mind.

I know the exact shape of that hope.

It is humiliating and holy at the same time.

Humiliating because you can feel yourself shrinking and still keep reaching.

Holy because beneath the desperation is something almost beautiful: the human refusal to believe love can really be that careless with us.

When the structure finally collapses, it does not just take a person from you.

It strips away the identity you built around being needed.

Who am I if no one is waiting for me?

Who am I if no one is choosing me?

Who am I if the love I organized my life around becomes a room I am no longer allowed to enter?

The honest answer is not empowering at first.

At first, the answer is: I do not know.

And that is where momentum begins.

You do the next thing because there is nothing else to do.

You drink water because someone on the internet said it helps.

You take a shower and call it a victory because it is.

You stand there longer than necessary, letting the water hit the back of your neck, watching mascara and conditioner and whatever was left of yesterday spiral toward the drain. You do not feel reborn. You just feel wet and tired and a little less impossible.

Still, that counts.

You send the email.

You open the document.

You walk outside even though the light feels personally offensive.

You buy coffee you cannot really justify. You sit in the car for six minutes after arriving because arriving and entering are different tasks. You put on earrings like a woman with evidence of a future.

You keep going, not because you have become brave, but because your body has not agreed to die.

That counts.

I need to say that again, for the women who have been measuring their progress against some imaginary healed self who wakes up peaceful and moisturized and free:

That counts.

There were years when the only thing I did consistently was continue.

Badly. Dramatically. Imperfectly. Sometimes in last night's makeup. Sometimes with my whole nervous system screaming. Sometimes with one shoe from one pair and one shoe from another kind of life.

But I continued.

And eventually, something strange happened.

The motion that once felt empty began to create space.

Not happiness.

Not yet.

Space.

A little room between the trigger and the reaction.

A little room between the text I wanted to send and the woman I wanted to become.

A little room between the old story and the possibility that I was not condemned to keep living inside it.

Momentum is not healing.

But sometimes it keeps you alive long enough for healing to find an address.

CHAPTER 3: THE MAN WHO WOULD NOT SAVE ME

The hardest boundary to accept is the one drawn by someone who used to have none with you.

There was a time when his love felt automatic.

Before.

That is the cruel little word grief builds a house around.

Before, he would have torn himself apart before letting me feel alone. Before, my pain activated him. Before, he stepped in before I even knew how to ask. He made my problems his, not because it was healthy, but because love had become indistinguishable from rescue for both of us.

I did not understand the danger of that then.

I thought it meant I was cherished.

And maybe I was.

But being carried is not the same thing as being known. Being rescued is not the same thing as being loved well. Sometimes it is just two people making a beautiful disaster out of need.

Years later, he sat across from me changed.

Composed.

Self-contained.

Kind, even, which was almost worse.

The table between us felt too small for how far away he was.

There was nothing obviously cruel about him. No slammed door. No performance. No villain monologue I could use later to make the story easier to explain. Just a man sitting there with his hands calm, his voice even, his boundaries arranged around him like furniture he had finally learned not to apologize for owning.

He said, "I can't be your savior."

There are sentences that do not sound cruel until they enter the body.

This one entered mine and found every abandoned room.

It went straight to the little girl in me who still believed love meant someone would notice the danger before I had to name it.

It went to the woman in me who had built whole futures out of tiny softenings in his face.

It went to the part of me that wanted to collapse beautifully enough for him to remember he used to catch me.

I wanted to argue with him, but there was nothing to argue with. He was not punishing me. He was not yelling. He was not trying to make me small.

He was simply telling the truth.

He could care about me and still not step in.

He could listen and still not fix it.

He could remember loving me and still refuse to become the man who lost himself in me again.

That kind of restraint felt colder than anger.

Anger at least reaches.

This was distance with a pulse.

I kept looking for the old reflex in him. The little crack. The softening. The moment when my pain became too much for him to witness and he crossed back over into us.

But he did not cross.

He stayed on his side of the boundary.

And I hated him for it.

Then I envied him for it.

Then, very slowly, I understood.

He had become the thing I needed to become: someone who could love without surrendering the deed to his own life.

I had spent so long wanting someone to save me that I had never asked what rescue would require of them. I wanted to be someone's reason, someone's exception, someone's soft spot, someone's unfinished business. I wanted my pain to matter enough to reorganize another person's boundaries.

That is an ugly thing to admit.

It is also human.

When you have lived too long without feeling held, you can start to confuse relief with entitlement. You want the person who once soothed you to keep soothing you forever. You want the old version of love back, even if it nearly destroyed both of you.

He would not give it back.

And the part that hurt most was knowing he was right.

I did not need him to save me.

I needed to become someone who did not require saving as proof of love.

But God, I did not want that lesson.

I wanted the movie version. The knock on the door. The "I never stopped loving you." The man who sees you at your worst and decides your worst is still worth building a home around.

I wanted headlights in the driveway. A long pause before the apology. A hand on my face. A sentence that made the last several years make sense.

What I got was quieter and meaner in the way true things can be mean.

Instead, I got the real version.

A person I loved sitting across from me and choosing himself.

At first, I thought that was abandonment.

Now I think it may have been the first honest gift he had given me in years.

He left me with myself.

I did not know what to do with her.

But she was mine.

CHAPTER 4: BLEEDING ON YOUR SHIRT

I do not think there is anything in this world I know how to do as completely as loneliness.

I know that sounds dramatic.

It is dramatic.

I have always had a gift for making the interior weather visible. I can take a feeling, put eyeliner on it, give it a soundtrack, and make it walk into a room like it has somewhere to be.

My loneliness has always had accessories.

Black eyeliner. Cheap perfume. A playlist that understands too much. A text drafted and deleted twelve times. A joke made at my own expense before anyone else can decide I am sad enough to pity.

But beneath the drama is a very plain truth:

I have been lonely almost everywhere.

Lonely in rooms full of people who loved me.

Lonely in beds beside warm bodies who meant it.

Lonely in my own chest, like even I did not want to be there.

That is the loneliness that scares me most.

Not the absence of other people.

The absence of myself.

There is a girl in me who learned to apologize before she learned to ask for what she needed. She says sorry when someone bumps into her. She makes her pain convenient. She bleeds quietly and then worries about the stain.

She is the girl smiling in the group photo while already planning how to leave early without making anyone uncomfortable.

She is the girl in the bathroom stall breathing through the part where she almost texts the truth.

She is the girl who can make everyone laugh and still go home feeling like a glass no one remembered to fill.

I have spent so much of my life protecting people from the impact of hurting me.

Do you know how exhausting that is?

To be wounded and still managing the room.

To be heartbroken and still trying to make the heartbreak easy to love.

To be the one on the floor and still ask, "Are you okay? Did I get any of this on you?"

That is not love.

That is training.

That is a girl who learned that being low-maintenance might make her more keepable.

I want to reach back through time and tell her that love is not supposed to require such excellent customer service.

But I understand why she did it.

She did it because need felt dangerous.

She did it because abandonment had taught her to be charming in crisis.

She did it because sometimes the fastest way to avoid being called too much is to become useful.

So she became useful.

Funny.

Insightful.

Sexy.

Forgiving.

Available.

The woman who understands. The woman who can handle it. The woman who will make a whole philosophy out of receiving less than she deserves because at least philosophy sounds more dignified than hunger.

But hunger does not become wisdom just because you describe it beautifully.

At some point, you have to admit you are still hungry.

I am still hungry.

For safety.

For consistency.

For the kind of love that does not make me perform emotional magic tricks for basic care.

For a room where I do not have to translate myself into something easier.

For a life where I am allowed to bleed without apologizing for the shirt.

I am learning that my loneliness is not a personal failure.

It is a history.

It is every unmet need that shaped me.

Every prayer that seemed to echo.

Every person who left and somehow became proof of
what I already feared.

But history is not destiny.

It is material.

And I am a writer.

That means nothing is wasted, even when it is awful.

Especially when it is awful.

I can take the girl who apologized for bleeding and give her
a page where she does not have to clean herself up first.

I can let her speak.

I can let her be ugly with grief.

I can let her be needy, furious, embarrassing, tender,
hilarious, and alive.

I can stop making her earn compassion by becoming
inspirational.

She is still here.

Bleeding.

Not apologizing.

CHAPTER 5: THE GIRL WHO BELIEVED TOO FAST

Let me tell you about a girl who believed too fast.

Not because she was foolish.

Because she was tired.

There is a difference.

Foolishness is not knowing better.

Tiredness is knowing better and still wanting this time to be different so badly that you start negotiating with your own intelligence.

I have done that.

I have seen the red flags and called them intensity.

I have heard vague language and translated it into depth.

I have watched a man perform mystery and mistaken it for meaning.

I have taken three days of attention and built a cathedral in my head.

I have mistaken a notification for a window opening.

I have watched three gray dots appear and disappear like a weather system.

I have felt my whole nervous system lean toward a screen.

This is the part of the story people love to judge from a distance.

"How could you fall for that?"

As if loneliness has never made them generous with evidence.

As if desire has never handed them a pen and said, "Here, finish the story."

I know what it looks like from the outside.

It looks reckless.

It looks desperate.

It looks like a woman old enough to know better acting like a teenager with Wi-Fi and unresolved attachment wounds.

Fine.

Maybe it was all of that.

But inside it felt like possibility.

And possibility is intoxicating when your life has become too small.

When someone looks at you like you are trouble, like you are special, like you are the plot twist they did not see coming, something ancient and starving can wake up in you.

It wakes up fast.

It starts lighting candles in rooms that have no lease.

It starts naming children, planning outfits, forgiving future disappointments in advance.

It starts calling adrenaline intuition.

The girl in me heard "you're in trouble" and translated it into "you're chosen."

Because nobody had taught her the difference between a man who wants her and a man who wants to see if he can have her.

That sentence still hurts.

It hurts because it is precise.

It hurts because there were times I made myself easy to possess and then wondered why I did not feel cherished.

I handed over the blueprint.

Here is where I am soft.

Here is where I am afraid.

Here is the exact sentence that will make me believe you.

Here is every place I have been left before.

Please do not leave me there too.

And then, when they did, I called it proof that I was broken.

But maybe the wound was not that I believed too fast.

Maybe the wound was that I had been living too long without enough steadiness to recognize performance when it entered the room wearing chemistry.

Chemistry is not character.

Urgency is not intimacy.

Someone's ability to make you feel chosen is not evidence that they know how to choose.

I have learned this the expensive way.

In bathrooms.

In beds.

On ferries.

On the Port Jefferson ferry, specifically, with the water doing that gray, indifferent thing water does when your life is

ending and everyone else is just trying to get where they are going.

There is a particular humiliation in crying around strangers who are eating snacks.

Your chest is splitting open and someone three seats away is opening a bag of chips.

In the sick little silence after the phone does not light up.

I have learned it while crying in outfits I bought for a woman I thought I might become by wearing them.

I have learned it while trying to make dignity out of the fact that my body remembered what my mind was trying to reject.

Desire can be humiliating.

So can grief.

So can hope, when it keeps showing up underdressed to rooms where it should know better.

But I do not want to shame the girl who believed too fast.

She was trying to live.

She was trying to feel something that was not dread.

She was trying to turn attention into shelter.

And if she chose wrong, it was because some part of her still believed choosing was possible.

There is something worth saving in that.

Not the pattern.

The pulse.

The part of me that still wanted a life big enough to be interrupted by love.

I can teach her discernment without killing her hope.

I can teach her to pause without making her cold.

I can teach her that a man who speaks in code may not be mysterious. He may just be hiding.

And I can teach her the most difficult thing of all:

Being wanted is not the same as being safe.

CHAPTER 6: WHEN YOUR FATHER BECOMES THE MOON

There are some losses that reorganize the sky.

My father is one of them.

I do not know how to write about him without sounding like I am reaching for something above me. Maybe because that is what grief does. It turns the people we cannot call into weather, signs, songs, lights, little coincidences we pretend not to need and absolutely do.

Sometimes I talk to him in the dark.

Not formally. Not beautifully.

I do not sit beside a candle in linen and have a cinematic grief moment.

I am usually a mess.

Tears. Panic. Half a thought. A sentence typed too fast. The kind of crying that makes your face feel unfamiliar.

The room is usually ordinary. That is the insult of grief. It does not always arrive with ceremony. Sometimes it arrives while there are dishes in the sink, shoes by the door, a

browser tab open to something stupid, and a life that expects you to keep participating.

And then there he is.

Not literally.

But enough.

My man in the moon.

That is what I call him in my head sometimes. The presence in the darkness. The one I imagine watching while I try to make sense of the life I am still in.

We were supposed to go to the Grand Canyon.

That is one of the details that stays.

Plans are cruel after death because they do not know they have been canceled. They remain in the mind with all their ordinary little assumptions. A trip. A summer. A conversation you thought you still had time for.

If life were the story I could write, I would be somewhere like Arizona with him. I would be looking at something enormous and ancient, something that makes human pain feel both tiny and sacred. I would be making some joke. He would maybe pretend not to be impressed. I would still have access to the particular kind of safety that only existed when he was alive.

I imagine the heat first.

The dry air. The rental car smell. The ridiculous water bottle rolling under the seat. My hair behaving badly. Him pretending the view is not getting to him because awe, in some families, has to sneak in sideways.

I imagine standing at the edge of something carved slowly by time and thinking, maybe this is what grief is too. Not one clean break. Years of pressure. Water where no one thought water could win.

Instead, I sit here and talk to absence.

I talk to the part of him I still carry.

The part that believed in me without needing me to become less complicated first.

Anyone who has lost that kind of love knows the terror of trying to replace it.

You start looking for it everywhere.

In partners.

In family.

In strangers who say the right thing at the wrong time.

In men who feel familiar because something in you is still trying to get back to the first place you felt protected.

But nobody can be your father after your father is gone.

People can love you.

They can show up.

They can stay.

But they cannot step into that exact room in your heart and turn the lights back on.

I think some of my worst romantic decisions were really grief in costume.

I was not only looking for a man.

I was looking for a witness.

Someone to say: I see what happened to you. I see what it cost. I see that you are still good. I see that you are still my

girl.

That last part is the hardest.

My girl.

There is a specific ache in no longer belonging to someone that way.

Not as possession.

As protection.

As origin.

As a place in the world that cannot be revoked because you failed, gained weight, lost money, spiraled, cried too much, needed too loudly, or became hard to explain.

When that kind of love is gone, conditional love becomes even more dangerous.

You start accepting contracts and calling them homes.

You start trying to earn what you once received by existing.

You start making yourself into an argument for your own worth.

But my father, at his best, did not make me argue.

He had true faith in my abilities.

That phrase matters to me.

True faith.

Not brand faith. Not inspirational quote faith. Not the kind of faith people announce before disappearing.

The kind that sees the mess and still believes there is a person in there worth betting on.

I am trying to learn how to give that to myself.

It feels almost impossible some days.

But when the night gets dark enough, I imagine him where I need him to be: up there, quiet and impossible, reflecting light he does not have to explain.

And I keep going.

Not because grief has made me stronger.

Because love like that does not end cleanly.

It becomes part of how you survive.

CHAPTER 7: THE IN-BETWEEN IS STILL A LIFE

There is a particular shame in not being where you thought you would be.

Especially as a woman.

Especially when the world keeps handing you timelines like invoices.

By this age, you should have the marriage.

By this age, the children.

By this age, the house, the body, the savings, the career title that explains the years, the photos that make your life look coherent to people who do not know what it cost to stay alive.

I have wanted a family.

I have wanted children.

I have wanted the ordinary miracle of waking up inside a life that did not feel like it was always waiting to begin.

And yes, I have felt the clock ticking.

Not as an abstract cultural pressure.

As a sound in the body.

As grief in advance.

As anger.

As fear.

As the quiet math you do when no one is around.

There is a cruelty in being told you are still young by people who are not living inside your exact losses.

They mean well.

But reassurance can become another form of dismissal when what you need is for someone to sit beside the ache and admit it is real.

Some things may not happen the way I wanted.

That is a sentence I hate.

It tastes like defeat.

But avoiding it has not made it less true.

The in-between is where you live when the old dream has cracked and the new one has not introduced itself yet.

It is not a cute season.

It is not an aesthetic.

It is not the part of the memoir where the reader can already feel the breakthrough coming.

It is the long, fluorescent hallway between identities.

And you still have to eat there.

You still have to pay bills there.

You still have to figure out what to wear in a body that feels like it has betrayed you.

You still have to answer "what do you do?" when you are not sure whether the honest answer is "trying."

You still have to open mail.

You still have to make a password you will forget.

You still have to stand in front of the closet and negotiate with denim like it is a hostile witness.

You still have to make small talk with people whose lives appear to have loaded correctly.

I have hated the in-between because it makes me feel unchosen by life.

Like everyone else received a map and I got a box of receipts, a nervous system with trust issues, and a talent for making despair sound expensive.

But I am beginning to suspect that the in-between is not a waiting room.

It is a life.

Not the whole life.

Not the final life.

But life, still.

And if I keep treating it like a punishment, I will miss the evidence that I am already becoming.

The woman who sends the email.

The woman who writes the page.

The woman who does not text him.

The woman who does text him, regrets it, survives the regret, and learns something anyway.

The woman who looks at one shoe from one life and one shoe from another and says, fine, we are walking.

The woman who puts her hair up, takes it down, puts it up again, and goes anyway.

The woman who says "not today" to the worst thought, then has to say it again ten minutes later.

The woman who is not thriving, but is no longer willing to call herself nothing.

I do not want to romanticize this.

Some days are ugly.

Some days I am not proud of the thoughts I have.

Some days I feel behind every woman I have ever known and several women I have only stalked online for emotional self-harm.

But comparison is a thief with excellent branding.

It will convince you that your unfinished life is evidence against you.

It is not.

An unfinished life is still alive.

And there are worse things than being late to a life that is finally yours.

CHAPTER 8: BEGINNING BEFORE YOU ARE BEAUTIFUL

I kept waiting to become beautiful enough to begin.

Not objectively beautiful. I have had enough good days, good lighting, good eyeliner, and questionable men to know I am not without evidence.

I mean beautiful in the way women are taught to understand permission.

Thin enough.

Clear enough.

Stable enough.

Successful enough.

Photogenic enough to document the becoming without wanting to burn the archive.

I told myself I would start when I looked better.

The YouTube channel.

The essays.

The photos.

The public version of the work.

I would begin when my life looked less like a cautionary tale and more like an origin story.

I had a whole imaginary launch version of myself.

Her skin was calmer. Her room was cleaner. Her voice did not shake. Her captions were elegant. Her grief had become tasteful. Her body did not need strategic angles. Her past had been organized into a lesson with good lighting.

She was exhausting, honestly.

And she kept moving the start date.

But that is how women lose years.

Waiting for their own approval.

Waiting for the body to become smaller before the voice becomes louder.

Waiting for the evidence to be flattering before the truth is allowed to be useful.

I am tired of postponing my life until I can market the pain attractively.

The real version is not polished.

The real version affects your finances, your relationships, your sense of time, your ability to function. It makes your room messy. It makes your inbox intimidating. It makes basic tasks feel like moral trials. It makes you wonder how everyone else became a person with systems while you are still trying to remember where you put the thing you needed to become one.

This is the version I want to talk about.

Not because I want to expose myself for sport.

Because someone else is sitting in the same in-between space, convinced that their inability to look graceful while suffering means they have failed at suffering too.

They have not.

Neither have I.

I want to write.

I want to speak.

I want to help people who feel stuck, afraid, behind, ashamed, and secretly convinced that everyone else received instructions they missed.

I want to build something with words that makes people feel less alone in the rooms they cannot photograph.

Rooms with laundry on the chair.

Rooms where the bed is both office and hospital.

Rooms where the mirror feels like a witness for the prosecution.

Rooms where a woman is trying to decide whether this is the day she comes back to herself or just another day she survives.

Maybe that becomes content.

Maybe it becomes community.

Maybe it becomes a book, a channel, a room, a neon sign in the dark that says: you are not too late.

I do not have the whole thing mapped.

But I have direction.

For the first time in a long time, that feels like enough.

So I am beginning before I am beautiful.

Before I am healed.

Before I am impressive.

Before my life can be explained in a way that makes everyone comfortable.

I am beginning with the face I have, the body I have, the story I have, the voice I almost lost, and the small stubborn belief that my mess may still become a door for someone else.

This is not confidence.

It is refusal.

I refuse to wait until I am easier to love before I let myself be seen.

I refuse to let shame be the editor of my life.

I refuse to keep auditioning for the right to exist out loud.

And if only two people read this, or hear this, or find themselves somewhere inside these pages, that is not nothing.

That is a beginning.

Maybe beginnings are smaller than we were taught.

Maybe they are not announcements.

Maybe they are just the first honest thing we stop deleting.

CHAPTER 9: A PRAYER FOR THE WOMEN STILL ON THE FLOOR

This is for the women who are not rising yet.

The women who are still on the floor.

The women who hate the word resilience because it has been used too many times to make their suffering sound useful.

The women who have been told they are strong when what they needed was help.

The women who know the particular silence after being left.

The women who check their phones even though they know.

The women who miss people who were not good for them and feel ashamed of the missing.

The women who loved too hard, too fast, too publicly, too hopefully.

The women who became funny because pain needed somewhere to go.

The women who lost fathers, homes, bodies, years, names, plans, shoes, faith, and still somehow woke up inside another morning.

The women who made coffee with shaking hands.

The women who wore the same sweatshirt too many days in a row.

The women who looked at old photos and could not decide whether they missed the person, the body, the time, or the illusion that life was still going to be simple.

I do not have a clean answer.

I wish I did.

I wish I could tell you that one day you wake up and the hunger is gone. That you stop wanting the people who hurt you to understand. That your body becomes a place you never have to negotiate with. That grief becomes beautiful because you finally arranged it into the right sentence.

Maybe that happens for some people.

For me, healing has been less like arrival and more like interruption.

The old pattern starts, and something in me interrupts it.

Not always.

Not perfectly.

But enough to prove another self is in the room.

I reach for the phone, and sometimes I do not send the text.

I start blaming myself, and sometimes I ask who taught me to do that.

I feel the old loneliness open its mouth, and sometimes I answer back.

No.

Not today.

Not like this.

I am still learning to stay with myself.

It is harder than staying with someone else, because there is no performance to hide behind. No rescue fantasy. No audience. Just me and the ordinary work of not leaving.

But maybe that is what love becomes when it finally grows up.

Not someone arriving to save you.

Not a grand gesture.

Not a man, a job, a body, a family, a room, a check, a diagnosis, a miracle, a message, a sign.

Maybe love begins as the quiet decision to stop treating yourself like the least important person in your own emergency.

So here is my prayer for us:

May we stop apologizing for the blood.

May we stop calling crumbs complicated.

May we stop confusing being wanted with being safe.

May we forgive the girls in us who believed too fast.

May we protect their hope without letting it drive.

May we find our fathers in the moon, our mothers in the mirror, our future in the page, our proof in the fact that we are still breathing.

May we begin before we are beautiful.

May we belong to ourselves before anyone else knows what to do with us.

May the floor become a place we remember, not a place we live.

And when we cannot rise, may we rest.

When we cannot believe, may we continue.

When we cannot see the whole road, may we take the next honest step.

We are not too late.

We are not too broken.

We are not disqualified from our own lives.

We are still here.

Still becoming.

Still ours.

REFLECTION PAGES

If you want to stay with the book a little longer, use these as private writing prompts. There is no right way to answer them. Start where the sentence catches.

1. Where have I been calling crumbs "complicated" because admitting they were crumbs would hurt too much?
2. What version of myself am I waiting to become before I let myself begin?
3. What ordinary object from my life tells the truth about a season I survived?
4. Who did I want to save me, and what did I want them to prove?
5. What does my loneliness wear, listen to, eat, buy, text, or delete?
6. What grief am I trying to replace with romantic attention?
7. What would I write if I did not need the scene to make me look good?

8. What would "belonging to myself" look like in one small, boring, daily action?

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

♡ - MK is a writer and marketer whose work explores reinvention, grief, identity, voice, and the private work of becoming yourself again. She writes personal essays, memoir-driven nonfiction, brand stories, and emotional survival notes for women rebuilding after the life they thought they were supposed to have.

You can find more of her work at mkparrish.com.